

Interested or interesting?

Teaching guide

Describe a feeling and what causes it.

Understand the distinction

For many pairs, the -ed adjective describes a feeling: bored, excited, interested. The -ing adjective describes what causes that feeling: boring, exciting, interesting.

People can cause feelings too. A person can be interesting, and a story can be exciting. Choose by meaning, not by whether the noun is a person or a thing. After interested in, use a noun or an -ing verb.

Compare the patterns

FEELING

I am interested in photography.

This describes my feeling.

CAUSE

The photographer is interesting.

This person attracts my interest.

ACTIVITY

I am interested in learning more.

Use learning after in.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. The long wait made me feel ____ . (bored / boring)

2. Can a person be interesting?

3. Correct this: I am interested in learn Spanish.

Use it in your own life

Describe an activity and how you feel about it.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. bored

Describe the feeling of the person waiting.

2. Yes. A person can cause interest.

The distinction is feeling versus cause, not person versus thing.

3. I am interested in learning Spanish.

A verb after this preposition uses the -ing form.

One possible response

The class is challenging, but I feel excited about learning.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-03.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe an activity and how you feel about it.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.